BENJAMÍN ZÚÑIGA SILVA

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Profile

Political scientist trained in comparative politics, democratic theory, and quantitative and qualitative methods. Extensive experience building and analyzing original datasets and supporting research projects and centers. My research interests include state–citizen relations, state capacity, and democratic erosion in Latin America. Advanced proficiency in R/RStudio; fluent in academic literature in English and Spanish.

Education

M.A. in Political Science, concentration in Government and Public Policy *Aug 2026 – Jul 2027*
Pontificia Universidad Católica de Chile

B.A. in Political Science (Professional Degree) *Mar 2020 – Dec 2024*
Pontificia Universidad Católica de Chile

- GPA 6.3/7.0. Ranked 3rd of 36 in graduating cohort. Minor in Social Anthropology.
- Thesis: "Anthropogenic Climate Change and Political Legitimacy." Advisor: Prof. Ross Mittiga.
- Admitted to the M.A. in Political Science, McGill University (Fall 2027)

Experience

Research Assistant *Jul 2026 – present*
Prof. Juan Pablo Luna

- Review and editing of an academic book manuscript on populism in Chile and Uruguay.

Teaching Assistant *Mar – Aug 2026*
Prof. Felipe Aguila, "Introduction to Qualitative Research Methods." School of Government, Universidad Adolfo Ibáñez

Teaching Assistant *Aug – Dec 2025*
Prof. Juan Pablo Luna, "Democracy and Development." School of Government, Pontificia Universidad Católica de Chile

Project Manager *Aug – Dec 2025*
Millennium Nucleus on the Impacts of China in Latin America and the Caribbean (ICLAC)

- Led an international team of eight researchers in developing an interactive public data platform on foreign direct investment in Latin America, expanding coverage from 7 to 12 countries, including complex cases such as Venezuela, Guyana, and Suriname.

Research Assistant *Apr 2024 – Aug 2025*
Prof. Juan Pablo Luna, Millennium Institute VIODEMOS, Pontificia Universidad Católica de Chile

- Built in R an original comparative dataset linking citizenship rights with criminal, structural, and political violence in Latin America, integrating V-Dem, LAPOP, Latinobarómetro, and original coding.
- Conducted statistical analyses of state weakness, citizenship gaps, and impunity, and contributed to the theoretical framework on democracy, violence, and crises of representation.
- Contributed to a FONDECYT grant proposal on crises of representation and party system transformation in Latin America, reviewing the literature on polarization, political temporality, and insider/outsider dynamics.

Quantitative Analyst *Oct 2024 – May 2025*
MiniCOES Project "Crime Exposure and Educational Performance." Profs. Alejandra Abufhele, Naim Bro, and Juan Pablo Luna, COES

- Built in R a georeferenced dataset linking criminal events to educational outcomes in Santiago.
- Designed the project's empirical strategy, implementing fixed-effects models and geospatial analysis of risk concentration.

Intern *Jul – Dec 2024*
Millennium Nucleus on the Impacts of China in Latin America and the Caribbean (ICLAC)

- Verified and systematized data for a regional investment platform; produced *policy briefs* and op-eds, and supported academic seminars.

Research Assistant *Dec 2023 – Jun 2024*
Prof. María Montt, Millennium Nucleus on the Impacts of China in Latin America and the Caribbean (ICLAC)

- Comparative study of extractive investment governance in Africa and Latin America; statistical analysis of economic and institutional indicators.

Research Assistant *Jun – Sep 2022*
Prof. Francisco Urdinez. FONDECYT Project "Chinese Business and Structural Power"

- Built and analyzed a dataset on Chinese COVID-19 aid donations to Latin America, systematizing patterns across countries and administrative levels.

Additional Information

- **Software and analysis:** Advanced R/RStudio: data cleaning and wrangling, fixed-effects models, geospatial analysis, and data visualization; LaTeX/Overleaf; Microsoft Office.
- **Languages:** Spanish (native); English (advanced), TOEFL iBT 116/120.
- **Work in progress:** (1) Comparative article on the far right in Argentina and Brazil; (2) Article on political trends in Latin America, 2005–2025 (with Juan Pablo Luna); (3) Article on news media and crime in Greater Santiago (with Juan Pablo Luna and Camila Rojas).